OFFICE OF FAITH & NONPROFIT DEVELOPMENT SERVICES

August 2025 Newsletter

WELLNESS WORKS: FAITH AND NONPROFITS LEADING THE WAY TO CARING FOR OUR COMMUNITIES.

Governor Kathy Hochul shares her $1 Billion Plan to overhaul New York State's Continuum of Mental Health Care

Governor Kathy Hochul is taking pictures with the Buddhist Faith Leaders of New York State at the 2025 Interfaith Reception

The August edition of the Office of Faith and Non-Profit Development Services Newsletter centers on the theme “Wellness Works: Faith and Nonprofits Leading the Way to Caring for Our Communities.” This month, we proudly spotlight two remarkable faith leaders whose commitment to wellness within their congregations and neighborhoods has uplifted lives and strengthened the bonds between health and spirituality. Their stories reflect the powerful role that faith communities continue to play in supporting mental, physical, and emotional wellness across New York State. From food security programs to wellness education, their work reminds us that when faith and service intersect, communities thrive.

This newsletter also highlights several important statewide initiatives launched under Governor Kathy Hochul’s leadership. Chief among them is the Governor’s announcement that New York will become the largest state in the nation to implement statewide, bell-to-bell restrictions on smartphones in schools — a bold step to foster distraction-free learning environments. Additionally, we feature the $5 million Digital Equity Grant Opportunity to help more New Yorkers gain essential internet access and digital skills. Readers will also find resources such as the OASAS Parents and Mentors Cannabis Toolkit, the “Get Offline, Get Outside” campaign to reconnect with nature, and a renewed call for faith-based organizations and nonprofits to submit their revised events form to share upcoming programs and activities our office should be aware of and amplify. Together, these updates reflect our continued mission to support, uplift, and connect New York’s faith and nonprofit communities.

OFFICE OF FAITH & NONPROFIT DEVELOPMENT SERVICES

Faith Leader's of New York Spotlight Monthly Feature:

WELLNESS WORKS

Reverend Jacques DeGraff – Leadership Council of the National Choose Healthy Life Initiative

Q: How does your faith tradition define wellness, and how has that shaped your personal approach to health and healing?

A: In my faith tradition, particularly through my work with Choose Healthy Life (CHL), wellness is understood as a holistic state that encompasses spiritual, physical, and mental well-being. This belief is rooted in the Old Testament, where God commands us to "choose life," a powerful reminder that wellness is both a divine directive and a conscious decision. For the past five years, I have served as the New York State Clergy Leader for CHL, helping to lead a network of 30 churches across six cities. The COVID-19 pandemic revealed deep disparities in our healthcare system, especially for the Black community. In response, the church stepped up, not only as a place of worship but as a center of health education, service, and support. Our faith compels us to bridge those gaps, to affirm science while grounding our work in scripture. The Church has always been in the saving business. Now, we use our faith tradition as a vehicle to guide our communities toward true wellness.

Q: Why is it important for faith leaders to engage with government and nonprofit agencies to advance wellness?

A: Faith leaders have a unique and trusted voice in our communities, but we don't work in isolation. No one stands alone. The church is part of a broader society that includes vital institutions like government agencies, nonprofit organizations, and healthcare providers that have the tools and resources to serve the public.

The partnership between NYS government and nonprofit organizations is formidable. Throughout the pandemic, we saw clearly how collaboration could save lives. When churches were closed, we adapted by bringing people together virtually, and later in person, to provide both information and care. Many in our communities have had negative experiences with the healthcare system. That's why partnerships matter: when government and nonprofits work with the Church, it builds trust and increases impact and is the key to healing and hope. Together, we've confronted the mental health crisis that followed the pandemic, especially among young people. Suicide rates and emotional distress have risen sharply. It is essential that we work across sectors, as a united front, to bring healing and hope to the people we serve.

Q: Are you currently preparing for any new initiatives focused in wellness?

A. Yes, I am deeply focused on the wellness of young people, particularly in the aftermath of COVID-19. As a founding member of the Eagle Academy network of schools, I have had the opportunity to influence young boys' education across NYC. In my role as Chair of the NYC Chancellor's Interfaith Advisory Council, I help lead citywide initiatives that foster peace and understanding. Our work has collectively decreased hate incidents by 45%, which is a powerful testament to the role that faith leaders can play in shaping inclusive and hopeful learning environments.

As someone who was mentored by Rev. Dr. Wyatt T. Walker, Dr. Martin Luther King Jr.'s chief of staff, I have always believed in the transformative power of faith in public life. My work spans criminal justice, education, human rights, and health. Through it all, wellness remains a central focus because without hope, there is no healing. And faith leaders are called to be champions of hope.

OFFICE OF FAITH & NONPROFIT DEVELOPMENT SERVICES

Faith Leader's of New York Spotlight Monthly Feature:

WELLNESS WORKS

LAMA ARIA DROLMA – Lama at Palpung Thubten Choling Monastery

County Liaison for Dutchess County, NYS Office of Faith and Non-Profit Development Services

Q: What inspired you to integrate wellness work into your role as a faith leader?

A: My journey into wellness work, came about organically from my spiritual path. While I may not be a licensed faith leader in the traditional sense, I completed a cloistered three-year retreat program in advanced meditation in Tibetan Buddhism, which deeply transformed my understanding of inner well-being. The experience instilled in me a strong commitment to share the teachings of mindfulness, meditation, and compassionate practices, not just as spiritual tools, but as essential supports for mental, emotional, and physical wellness. Over the years, I have been fortunate to teach internationally and offer wellness programs across diverse settings, from universities to medical institutions and information technology (IT) companies, helping individuals from all walks of life cultivate resilience, clarity, inner peace, and a deep sense of well-being.

Q: What advice would you give to other faith leaders looking to launch wellness initiatives in their own communities?

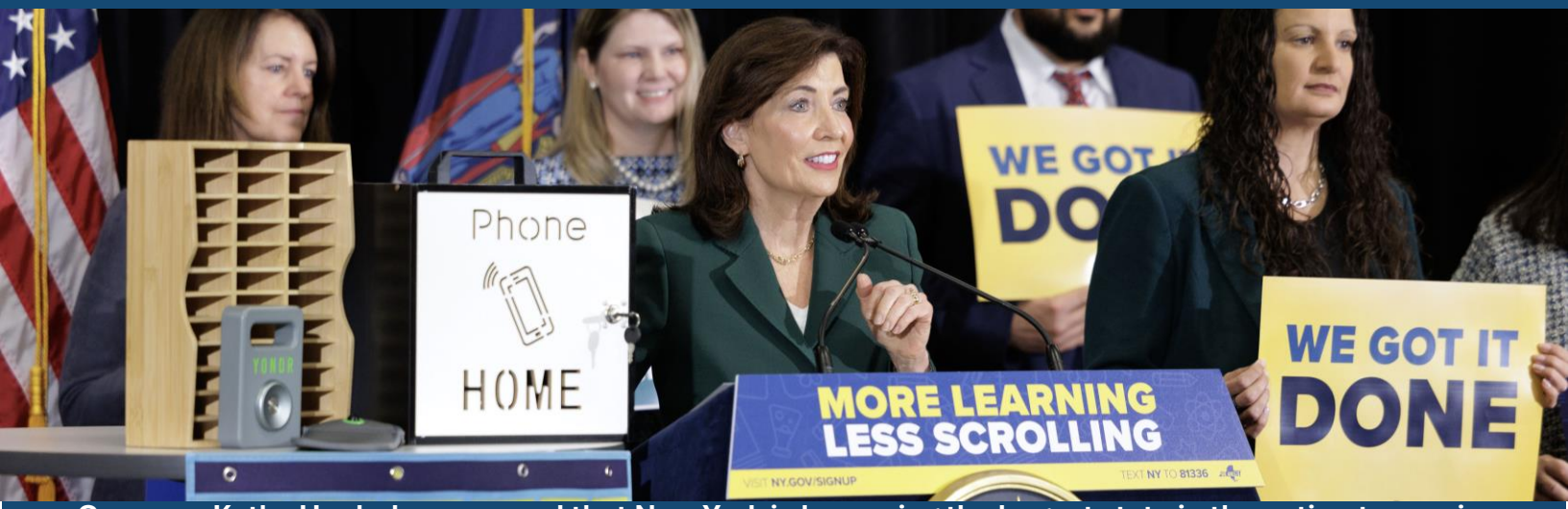
A: I've learned that wellness initiatives are most impactful when they are rooted in authenticity and compassion. My advice to other faith leaders is to begin with your own tradition of spiritual practice, Taking time to listen to the needs of your community, every tradition and neighborhood carries its own rhythms. Start with small, sustainable offerings, perhaps a mindfulness meditation session, a healing circle, or moments of silence woven into existing gatherings. It's about creating safe and sacred spaces where people feel seen, supported, and empowered to care for their whole being. And do collaborate, with other wellness practitioners, mental health professionals, or leaders from other traditions. True healing is holistic, and our collective wisdom can serve humanity in powerful ways.

Q: Are you currently preparing for any new initiatives focused in wellness?

A: Yes, I am currently developing several new initiatives to integrate mindfulness and wellness, particularly in response to the growing need for mental and emotional support across all sectors of society. One upcoming project focuses on creating accessible mindfulness meditation and resilience workshops for professionals in high-stress environments which includes healthcare workers.

Another Important project which is close to my heart is for the youth, including college students, who are facing depression and emotional challenges. Young people today encounter significant pressures, from academic stress to social and personal uncertainties that impact their mental health. This initiative offers mindfulness-based coping techniques combined with compassionate self-care practices designed to help youth regulate emotions, manage stress, and build resilience. The aim is to empower young people through workshops to understand their mental well-being, develop healthy coping skills, and cultivate inner peace and balance during challenging times.

Distraction-Free Schools: Governor Hochul Announces New York to Become the Largest State in the Nation With Statewide, Bell-to-Bell Restrictions on Smartphones in Schools



Governor Kathy Hochul announced that New York is becoming the largest state in the nation to require statewide, bell-to-bell restrictions on smartphones in K-12 schools. The Governor secured this landmark victory as part of the agreement on the FY 2026 State Budget. Following this agreement and the enactment of the FY 2026 State Budget, New York State's distraction-free schools' policy will take effect this fall for the 2025-2026 school year. Today's announcement builds on Governor Hochul's nation-leading commitment to protecting youth mental health and promoting student success in the digital age, following her action last year to secure and sign a first-in-the-nation law to restrict addictive social media feeds for minors.

"New York was the first state to target addictive social media feeds — and now we're the largest state to restrict smartphones in schools throughout the entire school day," **Governor Hochul said.** "I know our young people succeed when they're learning and growing, not clicking and scrolling — and that's why New York continues to lead the nation on protecting our kids in the digital age."

Additionally, the Governor's policy includes several exemptions to smartphone restrictions, including for students who require access to an internet-enabled device to manage a medical condition, where required by a student's Individualized Education Program (IEP), for academic purposes, or for other legitimate purposes, such as translation, family caregiving and emergencies.

Governor Hochul pursued this initiative after engaging in a statewide listening tour with teachers, parents, and students, and gathering findings to support the need for greater cellphone restriction in our schools. Her report "More Learning, Less Scrolling: Creating Distraction-Free Schools" includes:

Smartphones distract students and inhibit learning and creativity.

Phone-free environments do not compromise student safety.

Phone-free environments support the mental health of students and teachers.

Open communication and direct guidance for all stakeholders is key for successful implementation.

Schools must address any parent concerns about staying in contact with their children during the day.

An effective distraction-free policy must focus on the entire school day, rather than solely on time in the classroom.

Schools can strengthen their distraction-free environment by connecting more students with in-person engagement like clubs, sports, arts and other programming.

GOVERNOR HOCHUL ANNOUNCES OVER $5 MILLION DIGITAL EQUITY GRANT OPPORTUNITY TO EXPAND INTERNET USE AND SKILLS STATEWIDE

For Immediate Release: 7/23/2025 **GOVERNOR KATHY HOCHUL**

New York Continues Momentum of Broadband Access after Trump Administration Slashes All Funding for Digital Equity and Education Programs

State Launches New Affordable Internet Outreach Effort Focused on Households Covered Under the New York State Affordable Broadband Act

Download Multilingual Flyer in English and Spanish on Low-Cost Internet Options Through the Affordable Broadband Act

Governor Kathy Hochul today announced the re-release of the ConnectALL Digital Equity Program Capacity Grant Request for Applications (RFA), committing over $5 million in State funding to continue New York's digital equity grantmaking after federal funding was terminated by the Trump administration in May 2025. The ConnectALL Digital Equity Program will award grants across the state to support digital equity and inclusion projects that provide New Yorkers with devices, skills, and awareness needed to make use of affordable, reliable broadband service. Applications are due August 25, 2025, at 11:59 p.m. ET and must be submitted through the New York State Consolidated Funding Application Portal at https://apps.cio.ny.gov/apps/cfa.

"Digital access is essential for success in today's world — whether it's applying for a job, completing schoolwork, accessing health care, or staying connected to loved ones. In New York, we believe that access to affordable, reliable internet is a basic right, not a luxury," **Governor Hochul said.** "That's why we are taking action to ensure every New Yorker has the tools, skills, and support they need to thrive in the digital age. No matter the challenges, we will continue forging ahead — investing in communities, strengthening partnerships, and delivering on our promise of a more connected and equitable future."

Empire State Development President, CEO, and Commissioner Hope Knight said, "Digital equity is essential to economic mobility, educational access, and full participation in modern life. New York State remains unwavering in our commitment to ensuring that every community — urban, rural, and everything in between—can connect to the resources and opportunities the digital world offers. Through continued investment, strong partnerships, and innovative strategies, we are moving forward to close the digital divide and build a more inclusive future for all New Yorkers."

Governor Hochul also announced a campaign to educate New Yorkers on the low-cost internet service options available under New York State's Affordable Broadband Act (ABA) — the nation's first legally mandated low-cost broadband option. Under the ABA, internet service providers are required to offer internet connections for $20/month or less and to promote and provide enrollment guidance to consumers.

By re-releasing the Digital Equity Program RFA, ConnectALL reaffirms the Governor's commitment to address barriers to internet adoption and access and enhance the opportunities and security for New Yorkers using the internet by:

- Increasing access to affordable broadband subscriptions
- Providing access to internet devices
- Expanding digital literacy programs
- Protecting the privacy and safety of residents, and
- Ensuring the accessibility of government services

CONT'D- GOVERNOR HOCHUL ANNOUNCES OVER $5 MILLION DIGITAL EQUITY GRANT OPPORTUNITY TO EXPAND INTERNET USE AND SKILLS STATEWIDE

ConnectALL will work with state and local partners to promote enrollment in low-cost internet options secured for eligible consumers through the Affordable Broadband Act.

This groundbreaking legislation has earned national recognition, with ConnectALL winning the National Association of Telecommunications Officers and Advisors (NATOA) Community Broadband and Digital Equity Award for 2025 Broadband Visionary/Legislative Achievement of the Year.

ConnectALL will partner with New York City and State agencies to engage with eligible households, make them aware of low-cost internet plans, and support their enrollment. This partnership will implement a multi-channel outreach strategy that includes multilingual flyers, text campaigns to households receiving public benefits, summer street and back-to-school outreach, information via NYC 3-1-1, and a plain language self-enrollment guide, among other actions. In addition, the State is investing $500,000 in 2-1-1 NY, a subsidiary of the United Way New York, to launch ABA support for 2-1-1 callers with screenings and targeted enrollment guidance for up to 10,000 low-income households seeking reduced-cost internet services outside of New York City.

Expanding New York's Digital Infrastructure

Governor Hochul has made expanding broadband access a cornerstone of her administration's efforts to create a more equitable New York. Through the ConnectALL initiative, New York State is investing over $1 billion to transform the state's digital infrastructure, enhance competition among providers, and ensure that every New Yorker has access to reliable, affordable high-speed internet. To date, ConnectALL has overseen the successful launch and implementation of several programs to advance broadband access, including:

- The Digital Equity Program is implementing the $50 million New York State Digital Equity Plan to close the digital divide. The Plan outlines New York's statewide strategy to increase its capacity to improve digital literacy and digital job readiness skills, facilitate access to affordable internet and devices, enhance digital privacy and safety, and make government services more accessible through the internet.
- The Municipal Infrastructure Program has awarded over $242 million to support construction of open access municipal broadband networks across the state. The program, funded by the U.S. Department of the Treasury under the American Rescue Plan's Capital Projects fund, facilitates a variety of models of municipal broadband and public-private partnerships to provide New Yorkers with affordable, high-quality service options. Information on projects funded through this program is available on the ConnectALL Projects Dashboard (Beta).
- The Affordable Housing Connectivity Program will bring new broadband infrastructure to homes in affordable and public housing leveraging federal support from the U.S. Treasury Department's Capital Projects Fund as part of an overall $100 million investment. Information on projects funded through this program is available on the ConnectALL Projects Dashboard (Beta).
- The ConnectALL Deployment Program will provide funding for internet service providers to reach unserved and underserved locations, drawing on an allocation of $664.6 million in federal funding as described in the ConnectALL Broadband Deployment Initial Proposal. ConnectALL is currently accepting applications and prequalification applications with information available on the ConnectALL website.

- The Connectivity Innovation Program advances innovation and new broadband solutions, business models, and technologies in order to increase private sector investment and entrepreneurship; drive equity and innovation in the broadband marketplace; and reinforce a thriving research, development, and manufacturing ecosystem to support connectivity innovation in New York. ConnectALL is reviewing applications to the Connectivity Innovation – Mobile Service RFA, which closed in June 2025.
- The Excelsior Broadband Network is a new statewide public broadband network. The first component of this project will be a new fiber line running the full length of the New York Thruway which will connect public broadband assets across the state and improve access to consistent high-speed internet and reliable cell phone service for communities across the state.
- The Mobile Service Connectivity initiative will work with local stakeholders, state agencies, and industry to develop regional plans to expand cellular coverage across the state. The program will identify top opportunities to expand coverage and provide funding to deploy innovative, scalable solutions that can address gaps in wireless cellular coverage.

DEADLINE APPROACHING!!! DASNY CAPITAL GRANT

$100 Million New York Building Recreational Infrastructure for Communities, Kids and Seniors (NY BRICKS) Capital Grant Program

The application period for the NY BRICKS Capital Grant Program has opened on July 14, 2025, and applications must be submitted by August 15, 2025.

Governor Hochul secured this funding in the FY 2026 Enacted Budget to support municipalities and nonprofit organizations in building or renovating community centers that promote physical health, mental well-being, and community connections for youth and older adults. NY BRICKS will offer grants of up to $15 million to fund design, construction, renovation, and land acquisition for these centers. Priority will be given to projects in underserved communities, as well as those offering affordable services like childcare, eldercare, and mental health counseling. The program aims to make transformative, high-impact investments in local communities. This announcement builds on Governor Hochul's 'Unplug and Play' initiative to get kids off of their phones by funding playgrounds, community centers, affordable sports programs and recreational opportunities.

Awards are expected to be announced no earlier than November 1, 2025. Applications will be evaluated on characteristics of projects' need, impact, and viability. NY BRICKS grants will require applicants to provide a 20 percent matching contribution towards the overall project cost. Not-for-profit entities must receive approved prequalification status in the Statewide Financial System (SFS) prior to the submission of their application and must remain prequalified through the execution of the Grant Disbursement Agreement and payment of all requisitions.

For More Information Click HERE

NY BRICKS - Informational Webinar (Recorded June 25, 2025)

Potential applicants may not contact DASNY directly or through a third party to ask questions about an open procurement, as to do so is a violation of applicable procurement laws.

PARENTS & MENTORS CANNABIS TOOLKIT

Information for Parents and Mentors

Click HERE

THE CANNABIS TOOLKIT

OASAS
Every Step of the Way.

Recent Highlights

Department of State
Office of Faith & Nonprofit Development Services

GET OFFLINE, GET OUTSIDE

Governor Hochul is encouraging all New Yorkers to get offline and get outside! The "Get Offline, Get Outside" campaign encourages New York's kids and families to put down their phones and computers, take a break from social media, enjoy recreation and outdoor social gatherings, and put their mental and physical health first.

- **Governor Hochul Announces 'Summer Saturday' Discounts Returning for Long Island Railroad and Metro-North Railroad Monthly Ticket Holders:** Monthly Ticket Holders Can Travel to Any Stops on Either Commuter Railroad and Bring up to Two Additional Passengers for $1 Each. Encourages Riders To Travel and Explore Different Towns on the Commuter Railroads at an Affordable Price. This initiative encourages residents to explore new destinations across the region — from Long Island beaches and Broadway shows to Hudson Valley hiking trails and day trips through Connecticut — while helping families save money this summer.

Please note:

- Discounted tickets apply only on Saturdays
- This promotion does not include cross-honoring between railroads (i.e., LIRR tickets cannot be used on Metro-North, and vice versa)
- Certain Montauk Branch and Ronkonkoma trains are excluded (details available in the press release)

To learn more, read the full announcement here: Read the Press Release

- **Governor Hochul Highlights $250 Million Available in Food Assistance for Over Two Million Children Across New York This Summer.** Governor Kathy Hochul announced that New York has begun issuing more than $250 million in food assistance to an estimated 2.2 million low-income children as part of the 2025 Summer Electronic Benefits Transfer, Summer EBT, program. New York State is sending $120 per child to eligible families to help pay for food during the summer, when students lose access to free school meals.
- **New support for cooling at home:** With the NEW Essential Plan Cooling program, NY State of Health will provide eligible Essential Plan members a free air conditioner to help keep their homes cool. This will complement the assistance available in 2025 through the HEAP Cooling program , which served more than 23,000 households in 2024.

UPCOMING EVENTS

Not-for-Profit Contracting Advisory Committee Meeting

- September 16, 2025, from 12pm – 1:30 pm.
- To attend in person, there will be in-person locations: **New York City**: 919 Third Avenue, 45th Floor, New York NY 10022)
- **Albany:** (State Capitol, 2nd Floor, Conference Room #214-2)
- To attend the meeting virtually, here is the registration link: https://www.zoomgov.com/webinar/register/WN_qbDwhdgHQpWOcJp0f7Gh3w, which can also be found on their website at New York State Nonprofit Unit.

STAY CONNECTED

Connect with us!

Important Interfaith Dates in August

- August 2nd -3rd: - Tisha B'Av (Jewish)
- August 15th : Feast of the Assumption of Mary (Christian/Catholic)
- August 16th: Krishna Janmashtami (Hindu)
- August 21st - 28thb : Paryushan (Jain)

To join our mailing list for faith-based and nonprofit organizations?

CLICK HERE.

Do you have a faith-based or nonprofit event we should know about?

CLICK HERE.